

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Alignment primer

Morpheme classification & Glossing



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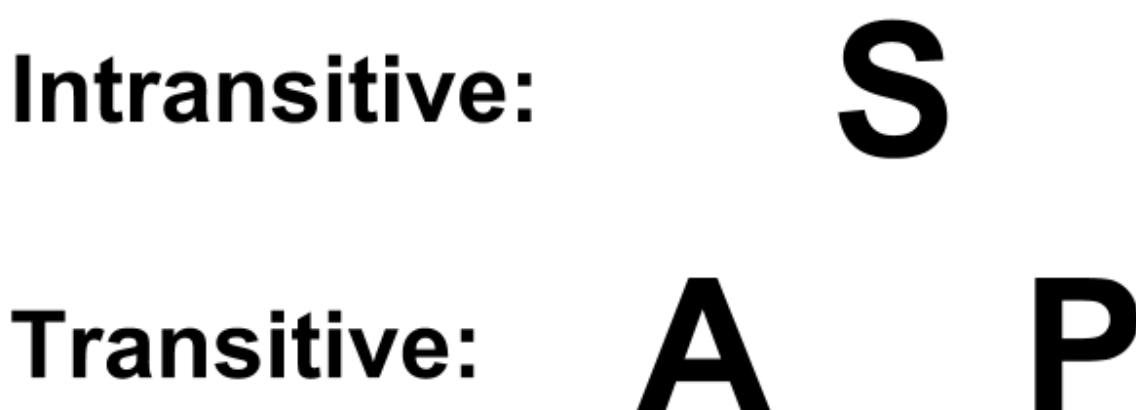
Introduction

I bet a lot of conlangers remember where they were when they first learned about ergativity. I had heard of it mentioned as something *exotic* that *weird* languages like Basque and Georgian did to their nouns. I didn't properly learn about it until I took Ling 101 in college, when the professor demonstrated that the way we categorize things in English is far from the only option. In this intro, I'm going to break down what morphosyntactic alignment is, show how some natlangs and conlangs do it, and hopefully spark some thought on how your conlang aligns.

S/A/P model

Morphosyntactic alignment describes how a language groups the various arguments of its verbs. Like you learned in the section on transitivity, a **transitive verb** is one with two arguments, and an **intransitive verb** is one with only one argument. You can think of these as representing three different kinds of argument. There's the **subject** which here is the sole argument of an intransitive verb, the **agent** which is the argument of an intransitive verb that performs the action, usually with some degree of control, and the **patient** which is the argument of an intransitive verb that undergoes the action. In English we can use the word "subject" to refer to either the subject of an intransitive verb *or* the agent of a transitive verb, so it's important to remember that when we use the term here, it's *only* to talk about the subject of an *intransitive verb*. It's also important to distinguish between the *syntactic* roles, which are described here, and *semantic* roles, which you'll learn more about in later lessons. Syntactic roles are defined in terms of how the arguments interact with other parts of the sentence, whereas semantic roles are defined in terms of what role a particular argument really plays in the event. So a syntactic subject could be a semantic agent, a semantic patient, an experiencer, or something else.

The graphic below summarizes the three kinds of argument we're talking about. **S** for "subject," **A** for "agent," and **P** for "patient."



Languages group them in different ways. The most common way is to group S with A, next is to group S with P. It is rarer but possible to group A with P or to keep all three distinct.

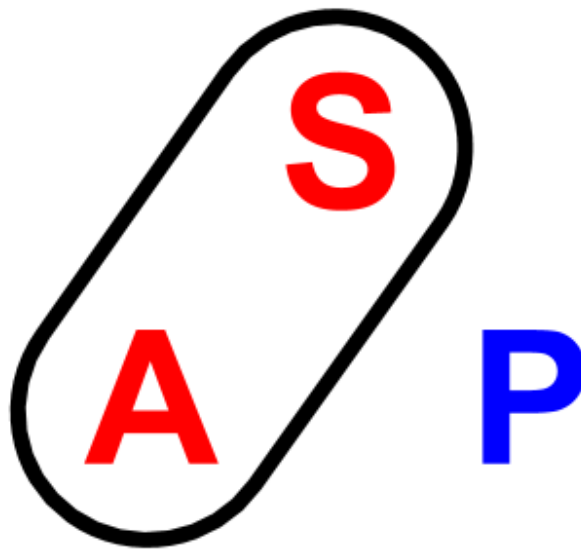
Since A and P can occur in the same sentence, but play very different roles, it's useful for languages to have some way of distinguishing them. Often case morphology plays that role, marking the A and P differently. There's no need to specially mark S, because there's no other argument it might be confused with! That's why it's so rare to have a case that only marks S, but it's pretty common to have a case for just A or just P.

Accusative alignment

If you're reading this, then congrats! You can already speak a primarily accusative language! A language that treats the subject of an intransitive verb the same as the agent of a transitive verb is said to have **accusative alignment**. Accusative languages mark S and A with the **nominative case** and P with the **accusative case**. Generally, the accusative is marked with an affix and the nominative may or may not be as well. If the verb agrees with one of its arguments, it will usually agree with the nominative. The graphic below shows how an accusative language groups its arguments.

Intransitive:

Transitive:



Since I know you're familiar with English (Germanic, Indo-European), I'm going to use it as an example. First consider a transitive verb with an agent and a patient.

1. she help-s him
 3sg.f.NOM help-3.PRS 3sg.m.ACC
2. he help-s her
 3sg.m.NOM help-3.PRS 3sg.f.ACC

The agents are marked with the nominative case, and the patients are marked with the accusative case. English really only makes this distinction with its pronouns, but it's still clear that there are different nominative and accusative forms. Now take a look at the following to example sentences, which both feature intransitive verbs.

3. she run-s
3sg.f.NOM run-3.PRS
4. he die-s
3sg.m.NOM die-3.PRS

Both of these sentences have verbs with a single argument, the subject. In the first one, the subject is performing an action, and is more agent-like and in the second, the subject is undergoing an action, and is more patient-like. But in an accusative language, it doesn't matter! All subjects of intransitive verbs are marked with the nominative case, just like the A. Another aspect of accusative alignment is that if the verbs agree with one of the arguments, it's the nominative argument. In all the examples above, the verb agrees with a third-person singular S or A. The examples below show that agreement in English is only with the nominative.

5. I see Allen
1sg.NOM see Allen
6. Allen see-s me
Allen see-3.PRS 1sg.ACC

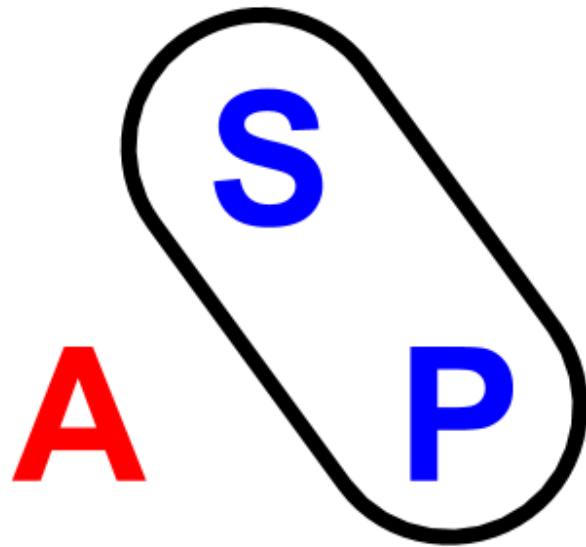
Some conlangers, especially people who are just getting started, look down on people who create languages with accusative alignment. *"It's just like English, and copying English is bad!"* they reason. Copying English is probably not what you want to do, but don't be afraid of accusativity. In the sample recorded in the World Atlas of Language Structures, 71% of languages with verb-argument agreement follow an accusative pattern and 57% of languages which mark case on nouns used the nominative/accusative scheme. This compares with 21% and 35% for ergative alignment respectively. It's not unoriginal to create an accusative language; they're actually the most common kind! But it is important to know that it's not your only option and that non-accusative alignments can be an interesting and fun element of language.

Ergative alignment

The second most common alignment is the **ergative alignment**. An ergative system groups the subject of intransitive verbs with the patient of transitive verbs, marking them with the **absolutive case** and leaves the agent of transitive verbs by itself, marked with the **ergative case**. The ergative is usually marked with some kind of affix, whereas the absolutive can either be marked or unmarked.

Intransitive:

Transitive:



For an example of ergative case marking, take a look at these examples from the Australian language Dyirbal (Pama-Nyungan).

7. yabu banaga-nyu
 mother return-NFUT
 "Mother returned."
8. yabu ŋuma -ŋgu bura-n
 mother father-ERG see -NFUT
 "Father saw mother."
9. ŋuma yabu -ŋgu bura-n
 father mother-ERG see -NFUT
 "Mother saw father."

In Dyirbal, the absolutive case is unmarked and the ergative case is marked with the suffix *-ŋgu*. You can see that S and P are grouped together as absolutive while A is distinguished. This is what an ergative case system looks like.

Another way that ergativity can manifest itself is in sentence structure. In English, the "subject" comes before the verb and the "object" comes after. The terms "subject" and "object" when used like they traditionally are in English grammar don't always work well when applied to other languages. Using the terms defined here, you could say that the *nominative argument* comes before the verb and the *accusative*

argument comes after the verb. Terms describing sentence structure like "SOV" and "SVO" are defined in terms of accusative alignment, but some languages' syntax may be better described in terms of ergative descriptors. Here are some examples from Mwanele (conlang, *a priori*). Just using a conlang for fun. This pattern is attested in natlangs too, I promise.

10. sun loṭ -o emen
 woman search-NFUT.IMPV cat
 "The woman is searching for a cat"
11. emen loṭ -o sun
 cat search-NFUT.IMPV woman
 "The cat is searching for a woman"

In these examples, the agent comes before the verb and the patient comes after. Traditional analyses would call Mwanele SVO. But I'm sure you can tell what's up next. Your ergativity spidey sense is tingling.

12. e- gwodu-lo emen
 INTR-play -NFUT.IMPV cat
 "The cat plays around"
13. le- kuna siju em epi
 RCP-shout unfortunately friend PL
 "Unfortunately, the friends argue"

Both of these clauses are syntactically intransitive. In Mwanele, the prefix *e-* marks an intransitive verb with a more agent-like subject and the prefix *le-* marks the reflexive/reciprocal voice in which the intransitive verb has one argument which acts on itself. Both of these would map to the subject, both in the S/A/P framework and in traditional English usage. If Mwanele were truly SVO, you'd expect them to come before the verb, but they consistently come after. Instead, Mwanele's sentence structure is best described as *ergative-verb-absolutive*. S and P occupy the slot after the verb, and A occupies the slot before it. Since this groups S and P together, but separately from A, this is an ergative pattern! There are lots of other interesting ways that ergativity and accusativity crop up, but they'll be covered in future lessons.

Tripartite alignment

Unlike accusative and ergative languages, some languages don't group S, A, and P at all, marking them all separately. Generally, in tripartite languages, the case used for A is called the ergative and the case used for P is the accusative. The subjects of intransitive verbs are marked with a separate case, which I've seen called the *intransitive* or occasionally the *subjective*.

Intransitive: S

Transitive: A P

Tripartite alignment is rare among the world's languages, but it is found in Nez Perce (Sahaptian).

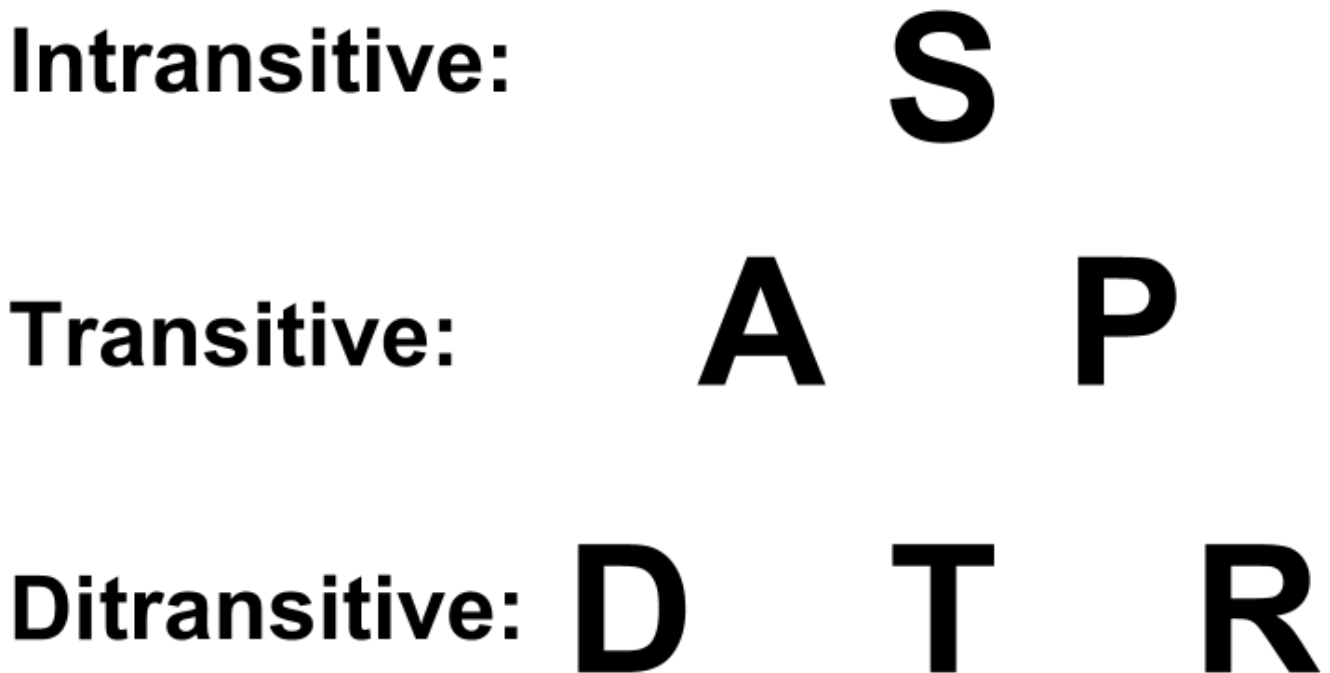
14. háama hi-páayna
man 3S-came
"The man came"

15. háama-nm pée- 'wiye wewúkiye-ne
man -ERG 3A>3sO-shot elk -ACC
"The man shot an elk"

In this example from Nez Perce, S is unmarked, A is marked with *-nm* and P is marked with *-ne*. You can also see that the verb conjugates differently for the two sentences, even though all arguments are third-person, singular, animate. The prefix in (15) *hi-* "3S" indicates that there is a third-person subject while the prefix in (16) *pée-* "3A > 3sO" shows that there's a third-person agent acting on a third-person singular object. Both the noun case marking and the verb agreement distinguish between S, A and P, so both are considered tripartite.

Ditransitive verbs

Traditional categories of alignment describe how languages group transitive and intransitive verb arguments, but it can also be interesting to consider ditransitive verb arguments. A **ditransitive** verb is one with three arguments. There is a **donor**, which performs the action, the **theme**, which undergoes the action, and the **recipient**, which receives the theme or benefits from the action. These are abbreviated as **D**, **T**, and **R** respectively.



A prototypical ditransitive verb is "to give." Consider the sentence "Aston gives Julian a new toy." Here, "Aston" is **D**, the giver, "a new toy" is **T**, the thing being given, and "Julian" is **R**, the one benefitting from the action. Generally, D is grouped with A, and is marked with either the nominative or ergative case. On the other hand P may be grouped with either T or R.

Indirectivity

Languages that treat P and T the same but distinguish R are called **indirective**. Indirective languages mark the patient and theme with either the accusative or absolutive case, and mark the recipient with a different case, often the **dative**.

Intransitive:

S

Transitive:

A

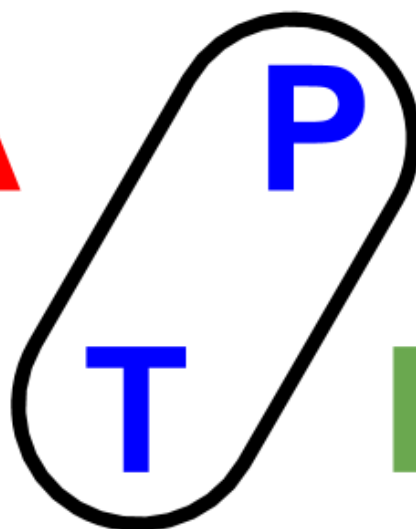
P

Ditransitive:

D

T

R



Most European languages are indirective, so I'll use one to demonstrate. Take these examples from French (Romance, Indo-European).

16. Thomas lit le livre
Thomas read.3s DEF book
"Thomas reads the book"

17. il le lit
3sNOM 3sACC read.3s
"He reads it"

18. Thomas donne le livre à Salim
Thomas give.3s DEF book to Salim
"Thomas gives the book to Salim"

19. il le lui donne
3sNOM 3sACC 3sDAT give.3s
"He gives it to him"

French uses the same series of accusative pronouns, such as *le*, to refer to P and T. It uses a separate series of dative pronouns, such as *lui*, to refer to R. It also has a special indirect object marker *à* which is only used before recipients. French is indirective, both in its pronoun case alignment and in its object marking strategies.

Secundativity

A **secundative** system groups P with R and treats T separately. For case marking in an accusative language, that means the recipient is in the accusative case, and for an ergative language, it means R is in the absolutive case. Some older sources use the term *dechticaetiative* for the same thing, but thankfully for those of us who don't speak Greek, that one didn't catch on.

Intransitive:

S

Transitive:

A

P

Ditransitive:

D

T

R

An example of a language with secundative case marking is Greenlandic (Eskimo-Aleut).

```
20. tuttu   taku-aa
    caribou see -3s>3s.IND
    "He saw the caribou"

21. uuma   Niisi aningaasa-nik   tuni-vaa
    3.ERG Niisi money   -INST.PL give-3s>3s.IND
    "He gave money to Niisi"
```

In the first sentence, the direct object is in the absolutive case (which is unmarked) and the verb agreement shows a third-person singular A as well as a third-person singular "primary object." In the second sentence, Niisi, the recipient, is in the absolutive case, and "money," the theme, is marked with the instrumental case. S, P, and R are grouped together, A and D are grouped together and T is by itself. This means that Greenlandic's alignment can be described as *ergative secundative*. You can also see secundativity in the verb agreement, where the "primary object" is marked as third-person singular. In Greenlandic, "money" is considered plural, so the verb must be agreeing with "Niisi" rather than "money."

You can actually see some secundativity in English as well, if you know where to look. When you make a transitive verb passive, it promotes the P to S. For example, "Jack read the book" becomes "the book was read [by Jack]" where P, "the book," is promoted to the subject. If you passivize a ditransitive verb phrase like "Jack gave Mary the book," you can say "Mary was given the book [by Jack]." Mary, the recipient, gets promoted to subject. Since English passives can group P and R together, this construction can be considered secundative.

Double object constructions

A third possibility is not to distinguish between T and R at all, and to treat them both like P. Both show up where you'd expect P, and neither is specially marked. T can precede R or vice versa, but the order is generally fixed. This is especially common among fairly analytical languages in Southeast Asia and in West Africa. Here's an example from Cantonese (Sinitic, Sino-Tibetan).

```
1. ngo5 bei2 cin2 lei5  
   1s   give money 2s  
   "I give money to you."
```

In a simple sentence like this, the theme, "money" and the recipient, "you" aren't differentiated at all morphologically. The only thing telling you which is which is the knowledge that in this construction, the theme comes first, then the recipient. For what it's worth, the opposite order is also quite common.

Conclusion

In this lesson, we've talked about different ways that languages can group the core arguments of a verb. Ergative systems group subjects and patients whereas accusative systems group subjects and agents. Tripartite systems distinguish all three. Secundative systems group patients with recipients, whereas indirective systems group patients with themes. When you're designing an alignment system for your conlang, here are some things to think about.

- Does your language use cases or other role marking? If it does, how does your marking group S/A/P? Ergative? Accusative? Tripartite? Something else? The ways I presented aren't the only way to group things. You could group A with P as "transitive" and distinguish S as "intransitive." You could group A with T and P with R, while distinguishing D.
- Does your sentence structure follow an accusative-based syntax or an ergative-based syntax or something else? Accusative-based word order is more common, even among otherwise ergative languages, but it's not a given.
- Do different features follow different alignments? English has mixed secundative and indirective features. Many languages have ergative noun cases but accusative syntax. Do some features change alignment depending on something else? Read on to learn about alignment splits.

Sources

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